

The Statue of the God Incarnate

—“Children, we received a letter!”

Varaz is waving something above his head as they all walk in. She then also quickly takes Āzar and Abrangih to their cushion in front.

—“Who is it from, Varaz?”

—“From Younā, remember, Borān, the Wailing Whale.”

Right, that was a funny story. But Varaz’s is holding a palm leaf, not a letter.

—“Where is the letter?”

He pretends to look around.

—“Wait, you don’t see it? *Pargast*, I must have misplaced it. It’s somewhere here, I am sure of it,” they all start looking around, until he looks at his palm, “oh, silly me, here it is, the letter!”

But there is nothing in his hand?!

—“What letter, Varaz?”

He turns his hand around.

—“See, the letter W!”

Varaz has drawn a W on his hand! Hee, hee, he tricked everyone!

—“What’s that good for?”

—“Ah, Shirowe, but it’s whalish. And in whalish, W is quite a big letter. But we will need an interpreter and luckily, I brought one with me.” He points to the palm leaf, where a little ant is crawling around.

—“The ant? How can an ant help translate? That’s just silly, Varaz.”

—“Do not underestimate, ants, Āzar. Do not think too little of our six-legged friends, as you will antly see in this story, children. But come, let’s listen to the content of Younā’s letter.

~“Dearest Princess and Knight. . .” Oh dear, children, the letter was not for us, but for the Princess and her Knight. We’d better get it to them fast.”

—“How, Varaz?”

—“With the aid of our little ant friend here. With her antenna, she will send the letter to the attention of her colleague who then will transmit it to our heroes.”

They all look puzzled at the ant. Could it be true? But the ant is just crawling around on the leaf, unaware of their stares. Of course not, it’s just one of Varaz’s jokes, ha, ha. But you have to play along, and then it’s double the fun.

—“Did they get it, Varaz?”

—“Oh yes.”

THE Princess is already reading it

~“... my writing this letter W to you is actually a favor I want to ask of you, esteemed Princess,” she looks up from the letter, throwing a glance at her Knight, “and also from that silly-question-asking companion of yours, I guess. It’s about my former master, the God of the Heavens and the Sky. As you recall, He went on retirement and now He has been incarnated in this beautiful big BODĀSP [Buddha] in Bamigān, shining splendidly as the white face of the moon. And the people go there on pilgrimage by land and sea from the furthest town of their country.¹ But that has drawn the ire of the King of the Huns, you know, the one wearing the Hat of MEHR, and so, I am a little worried about my former master. I would check it out myself, but that place is not whale-accessible. So, could you please go in my stead. I’ll stay put here, in case Queen Shamiram is again up to something evil. If so, I will write you another letter. Probably an *S. Paddrod* [bye].”

~“My Princess, which King of the Hun is he talking about?”

~“The one wearing the Hat of MEHR? Yeah, I don’t know either.”

~“And this place where He is incarnated, do you know it?”

~“Bamigān? Well, it is in the mountains, in the land of the Hun. But, my Knight, not words but deeds are expected of us. So, let’s go.” And so, our two heroes embark once more on a thrilling adventure to save the Statue of the God Incarnate! 🐉

This statue was something captain Mehrān had told him about. He sometimes had wondered whether the captain was not making up things when he was telling about his travels. But this particular statue, he has independent confirmation of its existence. The brother of *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens] Gordiyag had seen it himself together with her former husband. And the one time he had visited Ray, her brother had told him about it. Just as captain Mehrān had described it. Which made him belief

¹Ibn al-Nadim, *Fihrist*, IX.2.

that all the other stuff was true too. And it was just him who turned it into a fantasy world—and today, into an antasy world, ha, ha.

—“Varaz, how can the King of the Hun wear MEHR’s hat?”

—“Well, let’s hear it from the mouth of one of the local *brahmanag*—remember, children, that’s what they call their *mowbed* over there—, who is describing this extraordinary exploit of exaltation. Wow, I would never have thought that I would get involved?”

—“You, Varaz?”

—“You know what my name, Varaz, means in Armenian, right? It’s the same as in Persian: *warāz* [boar]. And that is what the King with the Hat of MEHR had used.”

THE *brahmanag* raises his voice.

~“Let me tell you how the God Incarnate defied the blasphemy of the King who wears the Hat of MEHR...”

~“If I may ask, Your Humbleness, why does he wear that hat?” There goes our Knight again with his inappropriate questions, children. I hope he does not draw the ire of the locals. But the *brahmanag*, he is a man of great self-constraint, and after a few deep breaths of Om! Om! Om!, he patiently explains

~“Because his head is flat.”

~“Huh?”

~“The royal Huns are all born with a flat head—here look at his coin.” Okay, children, I know you’re not going to believe me, so I brought an actual coin so that you can see it for yourself. 🍀

He hands Borān a coin with the head of one of the Huns. This coin he actually got from *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* Gordiyag who apparently defeated these or some similar Huns—she is glorious like that! She would make such a good heroine for his stories. Perhaps, one day, he is going to write an epic chronicle based on her adventures.

—“Oh, wow, look how flat his head is. That’s so funny.”

She shows it to Āzar and Abrangih and they start to laugh too. The others now also want to see it. Even Shirowe leaves his doorpost and comes take a look.

THE Knight thinks it’s funny too.

~“Yeah, I would wanna wear a hat too if I had that kind

of head."

~"So, now that your fatuous curiosity has been satisfied, let me continue with the relevant part of the story. So, jealous of the adoration which the God Incarnate received from the people of Bamigān, the Hunnic king, who manifested pride, who was cruel through want of proper training, who, from delusion, transgressed the path of good conduct, who was destitute of virtuous delights,² he decided to launch a counterstatue," before the Knight can object, the Princess puts her hand on his arm and shakes her head, "Out of stone, the jealous king carved this enormous boar, lifting up the earth out of the waters, causing the mountains to tremble with the blows of his hard snout.³"

~"Oh, no, what a dreadful demonic design! To use that noble beast for his own rank rancid rancor!"

~"... but the boar, although twice the size of a man, did not shake the statue of the God Incarnate: it remained undisturbed by this avatar of destruction. Praise the Gods. Go see for yourself." And indeed, when they wander onto this marvelous site of wonder, they are marveled by its marble wonder: there stands, twenty fathom [125 ft] tall, the God Incarnate.

~"Wow, my Knight, His foot alone is bigger than you."

~"I can barely see his head, covered almost in the clouds it is. That is some retiring in style."

~"And no harm has been done to Him. Younā will be relieved." But then the Knight notices something.

~"Look, where are all these ants going?" It's true, children, in a long line, ants are marching straight to the statue.

~"Perhaps they are going to worship Him too?"

~"Well, not all of them," he points to a group of them just standing on the side, apparently yelling something to the marching ants, "look, more of those insects."

~"Hey, don't insult us, we are antsects!" Yeah, ants don't like to be compared to those other crawling critters. The

²Mandasor Pillar, I.2.

³Eran Boar inscription.

Knight is curious.

~“What ant sect are you?”

~“We are Antifa!”

~“What does that mean?”

~“Ants for anti-fundamentalist antheism.”

~“Antheism? Is that your religion?”

~“Indeed, it is the most glorious faith on earth. And also the only correct one. But unlike my sister and her minions, we do not promote the destruction of the gods of the others. For that they call us dissid-ants, pff.”

~“I am not sure I follow. That statue over there, that is your God?”

~“No, are you kidding me?! Have you seen its size?”

~“Okay, perhaps it’s not life-size, or rather god-size. But the *brahmanag* told us they are going to build even a taller one. Look, the workers have started already. I think that mount is going to be its pinky toe. Imagine how big He is going to get.”

~“Preposterous!”

~“What, still not big enough?”

~“What an odd thing to say? To the contrary. It’s way too big. How can any divineness reside in there! God is not big!” And her companions now all exclaim

~“God is the littlest! Praise to God!” Our two heroes look puzzled at each other. That’s a first—and they encountered their share of fanciful fideistic phantasms.

~“You extol God’s miniscularity?” Puzzled, the Knight comes a little closer, making the ant taking a few steps back.

~“Wait! You are a Persian, no?”

~“Well, I strive to be one.”

~“So, are you then one of those giant anti-anters?”

~“Huh?”

~“Committing anticide by stomping on harmless us?”

~“Why would I do that?”

~“Well, there are some Persians who call us noxious, and that is just obnoxious. And then they want to trample us.”

Do you, children, know what she is talking about? 🐜

He never knows what to think of this Persian prescript to kill crawling insects. True, he has seen Persians do that, but Romans do that too, at least with spiders and those creepy bugs.

—“Yeah, Varaz, she thinks that she is *χrafstar*, and those are critters furthering the evil plan of AHRIMAN [Satan]. And we have to stamp on them!”

—“Oh dear, Āzar, you think these ants are demonic like that? Should we just stamp on them and be done with our story?”

—“Oh, no, Varaz. We should let them tell us their story.”

Of course, Shirowe has to come and spoil it!

—“Know, Āzar, that AHRIMAN [Satan] is propitiated by him who, when he sees a *χrafstar*, does not kill it!⁴”

—“Shirowe, don’t scare us like that! There’s no *mowbed* around.”

—“Well, children, it’s agreed then? No ant-bashing today. Okay, that’s a relief,” he turns to the little ant still crawling on the palm tree leaf, “You’re safe, little one.”

BUT back to your sisters. So, the Knight likewise reassures her that he has no intention to kill her.

~“So, antheism, that is against ant-stomping.”

~“No, although, we should perhaps include that in our charter now that you mention it. But no, antheism is the antithesis of antagonism.”

~“Okay, you lost me.”

~“You humans, you’re not very educated when it comes to metaphysics, are you?”

~“Truthfully, we are more like peripatetic pataphysicists, so, please enlighten us.”

~“Alright then, let me sing for you the Song of Creation. She scrapes her throat a few times, and then in falsetto, starts singing.”

*At the dawn of time
there was a single dot
and they were God. . .*

~“Wait, how can a single thing be many?” A little cross

⁴*Bundahishn*, XXVIII.21.

for being interrupted, the ant answers our Knight.

~“It is not!”

~“But you said ‘they’.”

~“That’s Their preferred pronoun,” luckily, the Princess intervenes before the Knight even further antagonizes the antsy ant, by putting her hand on his arm, “Can I sing my creed now? It’s a great insult to interrupt Their praise, especially as They like things small. So, as I was singing our antological anthem:”

*At the dawn of time
there was a single dot
and they were God
and then kaboom!
in fire and flame
the world into being came.*

~“Beautiful. But I wonder, why do you believe this?”

~“Because it’s the truth, physically as well as metaphysically. Euphorically as well as metaphorically. Antithetically as well as metathetically.”

~“Okaaay?”

~“Well, when our little pupa pop up out their prenatal pods, we always tell them this story, so that they would know the world in which they are about to enter. You might know it too, for it involves the King of the Jews.”

~“Solomon?”

~“The very same. And as you probably also told the children, Solomon had a magic carpet. And one day, he flew over the valley, and when the queen of the ants—she is my great, great, great...,” Alright, children, she went on for a full four minutes reaching the generation of her foremothers, so, let’s just skip to the ant, I mean to the end, shall we, “great grandmother, the Queen Ant Regnant—, she warned the others ‘O ants! Go quickly into your homes so Solomon does not crush you, unknowingly.’⁵ Solomon was curious

⁵Quran, 27.19.

why she spoke thus, and the Queen Ant Regnant answered that she was afraid if the ants would look at Solomon, they might be turned from their duty of praising God, which would be disastrous to them. When Solomon desired to ask her another question, she told him that it was not becoming for the interrogator to be above and the interrogated below. Solomon thereupon brought her upon his carpet, but she then said it was not fitting that he should sit on a throne while she remained down. Solomon now placed her upon his hand, and asked her whether there was anyone in the world greater than he. The Queen Ant Regnant, my great great. . .”

~“Your ancestor.”

~“Right, my ancestor, she replied that she was much smaller; otherwise God would not have sent him there to place her upon his hand. The king, greatly angered, threw her down, saying, ‘Dost thou know who I am? I am Solomon, the son of David!’ She answered: ‘I know that thou art created of a corrupted drop; therefore thou oughtest not to be proud.’ Solomon was filled with shame, and fell on his face.⁶”

~“I never heard this story.”

~“I am not surprised. Conveniently antathematized from their anthologies by those avid aphids.”

~“Huh?”

~“It’s a mystery to me why those with puny mind want to aggrandize themselves, distancing themselves even further from the divine. For the divine is the atomless atom, the undivided divide, the singeing singularity.”

~“God is the littlest! Praise to God!” So, children, that is in an antshell the doctrine of antheism, a very commendable faith, except for one tiny detail. ♣

—“What, Varaz?”

—“Hmm, it’s so tiny I don’t remember anymore.”

Varaz is again going on with all those silly sayings. It’s hilarious, ha, ha.

—“You’re pulling our leg, Varaz! But you haven’t told us what those other ants are up to.”

—“Oh, right! I’d better leave my silly antics to the antemologists. . .”

⁶Bet Ha-Midrash, V.22.

THE Princess inquires.

~“O wise ant, what are your fellow ants doing then, marching towards the statue?”

~“As I said, my sister the Queen Ant Regnant, she has ordained that the statue shall be destroyed!”

~“How?”

~“Well, go see for yourself!” The Princess and the Knight get closer to see what the ants are up to. Would you take a look at that! ♣

—“What, Varaz?”

EACH ant marches up to the statue and then kicks it very hard. And when a little grain of sand breaks off, she carries it away.

~“Where do you think they are taking the broken-off pieces, my princess?”

~“Perhaps to their shrine?” The sister of the Queen Ant Regnant overheard their conversation.

~“No, she has decided that everything should be dispersed, every grain as far away from the other lest they would convalesce again into an ungodly statue. And so, each grain will imbue the world with its divine puniness. A commendable project, but one we Antifa do not approve of. We believe in antruism: let the weak err greatly until they realize the error of their ways and humble themselves before God.”

~“God is the littlest! Praise to God!” The Princess doesn’t like what the ants are up to either. After all, they promised Younā that they would protect his former master. She pulls the Knight aside and whispers.

~“My fearless Knight, we have to do something.”

~“But how do you stop a whole army of ants? If we take one, two new ones will step in her place. I don’t think even your grandmama’s *Silver Book of Cantations* has a spell that can stop them.”

~“You’re 100% right—even more if that were possible—but there is something else we could try.”

~“What?”

~“A coup d’ant!”

~“Huh?”

~“A regime change,” the Princess turns back to the ant, “you say that the queen is your sister.”

~“And my aunt.”

~“How is that possible, wouldn’t that mean. . .” The Princess has to cut off our Knight once more, for ants’ antcestry can be very complicated, children. And it is impolite to inquire.

~“And being so closely related, do you two not look the same?”

~“We are identical except for our hair.”

~“Oh, how so?”

~“I wear mine to the left and my sister wears it to the right. That’s how we can distinguish between ourselves, lest I think she would be me. Imagine the confusion that would cause.” Anticipating an antagonizing Knight’s move, the Princess quickly asks

~“I apologize, o little one, but my eyesight. . . your hair, you are so little I can’t tell.”

~“My, thank you, noble Princess,” see children, the tinier, the greater the compliment, “but here, this is my hair.” The Knight now bends over and peers at the ant’s forehead.

~“I think I see one, a tiny black hair.”

~“That’s the one!”

~“You have only one?”

~“Why would I need more!?” The Princess’d better interfere.

~“So, this is my plan. You change your hair from left to right, and then we wait until your sister takes a nap and we swap you out for her, and then you lead the other ants away.”

~“Not a bad plan.”

~“O small one, do me a favor. Can you brush your hair to the right?” The ant picks up a tiny comb.

~“Okay. But be prepared to be confused.” But when the ant brushes her hair to the right, something strange happens. 🐜

—“What, Varaz?”

THE ant gets very antsy.

~“Why should I trust you foreigners. You’re here to make ants great again! Go away. We don’t take kindly to your kind.”

~“But, lady ant, we were going to help you to counterant your sister’s plot to destroy the Statue of the God Incarnate.”

~“Perhaps my sister is right. Down with those sacrilegious icons!” Oh dear, children, she now starts to act like her sister. Luckily, the Princess has found the comb, and she quickly brushes the hair back to the left.

~“Phfew, that was weird. I all of a sudden felt the urge to kick some chins.”

~“Yeah, you sounded a bit like your sister.”

~“Oh, no! I am never going to comb my hair like that anymore!”

~“*Āy wāy*, my Princess, your plan is not going to work.” The Princess ponders a little and then exclaims.

~“This is what we are going to do! I conjure a fake hair, and that’s the one we will comb to the right, making it look like your sister’s. But to hide your actual hair, we will color it brown like your skull, so no one will notice it!”

~“Okay, I will still be myself but look like my sister. But what about her?”

~“Well, we just comb her hair to the left, and hopefully that makes her feel more antipathetic against destroying statues of gods.”

~“But she will notice when she looks in the mirror!”

~“I thought when your hair is combed to the left, in the mirror it will look like it is waving to the right.”

~“Of, course, that’s mirror magic. My sister knows that too! We might be small—praise God—but we’re not stupid!” The Knight is not making things easier with his interruptions, causing the Princess to shake her head. But she has a solution.

~“We’ll give her a mirror mirror.”

~“Light of my Life, is that not double speak?”

~“No, double chirality is singular clarity!”

~“Huh?”

~“The double dual is plain straight!”

~“Uhm, double huh!?”

~“*Alā*, imagine you look in the mirror and you wink with your left eye. So, your mirror image will wink back to you with his right, right? Now imagine you’re watching this scene in a second mirror. With what eye will the mirror image now wink?” The Knight tries to imagine it.

~“Uhm, with both? No, scratch that. I know, with his left again.”

~“Indeed, Dusk of my Sun. The second mirror negates the effect of the first. But instead of two mirrors, we use just mirror symmetry: it’s easy magic, just string together a mirror and then mirror it symmetrically and you get a mirror mirror.”

~“Like the mirror image of a mirror?”

~“Close enough,” the Princess turns back to the ant, “So, little one, when your sister looks in it, she just sees her hair combed to the left—which it actually is, for she is watching it in a mirror mirror—and she figures,

~“That’s right, for I left mine to the right and the mirror rightly now shows it to the left.”

That’s what she will think, right?”

The Knight looks a little lost, but he knows that he should trust the Princess. And to reassure the ant, he adds.

~“Yeah, perhaps, after we switch her hair, she will instead erect a tiny ant statue for your God.”

~“How dare you say that! We do not antomorphize our God! We are way too large! That would be utter blasphemy!” Yeah, children, I think our Knight should better distance himself from the whole thing, before the whole ant world starts kicking him. But the Princess’s plan, the ant is still not fully convinced.

~“But, Princess, what about all our fellow-ants. We have to give them a new purpose.”

~“I think I have just the mission for them. Another wrong that I always wanted to right but never knew how.”

~“O my Princess, what evil should we ant-just?” The Princess shakes her head while the ant looks at him with some dis-

dain.

~“That’s not even a word!”

~“But... but, you guys are constantly using word plays like that.”

~“We are not playing anything. We are just talking regular ant-speech,” she turns away from the Knight, giving him the cold shoulder—her shoulder is pretty tiny, but still, it hurts, “But please explain your plan, Princess.”

~“Right! So, there was once a beautiful princess from Persia. Her father was a wise and soulful *Shāhān-Shāh* seeking peace with all his neighbors. And to please the emperor of Chin and Māchin, he offered his beautiful daughter as his bride...” That was in the old days, children, when princesses were missionaries of peace. ♪

—“I think I am going to write to the Emperor of Chin [China] to let him know that we still have some extra princesses here, in case he is interested.”

Oh, that Shirowe. He would send his sisters to such distant lands! Better ignore him and ask what is really important.

—“What was her name, Varaz?”

The inevitable name-demand. But this time he is prepared to give one, albeit the wrong one, ha, ha, but the children don’t know that.

HEr name was Vispānfryā. And this was what calamity befell her. Or, perhaps, it was a blessing. Who will tell? But let’s listen to the Princess telling her peer’s story.

~“And the *Shāhān-Shāh* sends a whole squadron of knights to accompany Vispānfryā on her long voyage. But when they cross the mountains and are about to descend into the valleys of Chin and Māchin, they are attacked by Huns. From all directions, ferocious brutes come running, yelling the most vile things I should not repeat here. So, the fellowship of knights decides that in order to keep their princess Vispānfryā safe, they will put her on a solitary mountain peak, very high and dangerous, which could only be approached by ladders, up and down.⁷ And so, for seven days and even more nights—well, she kind of lost count—she waits atop of

⁷Xuanzang, XII.

the rock, all alone. But the Beneficent Sun sees her ordeal. And He thinks,

~“Those godless Hun have already stolen My hat, and now they are about to steal this beautiful princess with her curly locks. I shall give her a son so that he may protect her.” And so, when the knights, after heavy casualties, finally are able to subdue the Huns, they go to get the princess from the rock, but to their surprise, on her lap, she is holding her newborn son. And they exclaim.

~“Here is he who has been born king. For we saw his Sun when it rose and have come to worship him.”⁸ The Son of Sun, a mightier prince never born before. But meanwhile, on the other side of the mountains, the people have been fearful of the Huns coming to their fertile lands. And when king Iskander [Alexander the Great] comes to claim their lands, they reply.

~“It’s all yours, Your Macedonian Majesty, upon one condition. We heard your an expert wall builder,” remember that story, children, how *Shāhān-Shāh* Iskander had built the wall to keep out the giants Gog and Magog, “So, we will submit to your will if you close off the pass between us and the Huns from Chin and Māchin. Build us a wall too!” And so, king Iskander, hoping not be be called accursed, sets about to build a wall. But when he arrives at the pass, he notices that the two mountains guarding the pass are standing too wide apart. See, king Iskander has brought with him these two big gates wrought of the sturdiest iron, to close off the wall. But the opening is just too wide. So, king Iskander lifts his hands into the air and prays to the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky to bring the two mountains closer to each other. Now, the Gods of the Heavens and Sky, they like Iskander, and so they hear his prayer and command the two mountains—they are called Bosoms of the North—, and they draw them so close,⁹ that there is no space left between them any more, completely closing off the pass—thus forming the Chest of

⁸Matthew, 2:2.

⁹Pseudo-Methodius, 8.7.

the North. And so, king Iskander doesn't even need his Iron Gates—and he puts them somewhere else. But don't ask me where, for I am not good with geography. But what Iskander did not know was that on the other side, princess Vispānfryā and her shining son had decided to turn around and return home. For princess Vispānfryā thought,
~“Why should the Emperor of Chin and Māchin have my Son of the Sun. He belongs to Erān, so that one day, he can succeed that accursed Iskander, who took my father's throne.” But when she reaches the pass, she finds it completely closed off by the Chest of the North, locking her out. And that's where, you, dear ants, can come to her rescue. Instead of kicking the Statue of the God Incarnate to little pieces, you can do that to the Chest of the North, until a passage opens up again, answering Vispānfryā's prayer

*I entreat the favor from the soul of this holy place
so that we can reach very fast
and see my dear family in good health.*¹⁰

So, that's the plan.” The Knight agrees that it is a good plan, and so, after the Princess conjures an antler on the ant's forehead and makes it look like her hair, but turned right, they go to her sister's chamber and wait until she falls asleep. And after they switch out the sisters, the Princess quickly combs her ant hair strand—I mean the the sister's hair—to the left. So, when the sister wakes up and looks, per her usual morning routine, in the mirror—remember, children, is actually a mirror mirror—, she sighs contently.
~“I look even prettier than ever. And what a gorgeous and righteous hair I have! It's a beautiful day today, and so, instead of turning right to that antiquated statue, to the left I will go, following my fellow-ants. Oh, and look at that: myself, I am already leading them. How nice of myself to anticipate my own change of mind.” See, children, she cannot tell the difference between herself and her sister anymore.

¹⁰Shatial inscription of Nanai-Vandak.

And therefore, no more antagonistic antolerance! And thus the colony, in unified unison, marches martially towards the Chest of the North, to fulfill their new destiny. Let's hope they can kick it down—well, the Chest, not their destiny, ha, ha. ॐ

—“And do they, Varaz?”

He stands up and pretends to stretch to look outside.

OH, I think so, children. The ants are kicking the conjoined mountains so hard that little by little an opening forms. And through the hole, the Princess yells ~“My long lost sister, have patience! We are coming to your rescue.” And after some more anthusiastical kicking, from the Chest of the North, emerges Persia's greatest treasure: the Son of the Sun and his immaculate mother, princess Vispānfryā. Amen! And thus an anthralling story comes to its anticipated ant. ॐ

He makes a little bow and then adds, with a little malice in his voice —“And don't forget children, if GOD is the smallest, and Evil is the complete opposite, it follows that AHRIMAN [Satan] is the biggest.” Why did Varaz have to add that? It was such a good story, but she doesn't want to imagine a gigantic devil! The others giggle, so she just does the same. It's true, it is just a made-up story! But where did the ant on the palm leaf go?

By now, he knows the routine. Wait for the children to leave for the *Bāmbishn* to address him.

—“The inscription on this coin,” she hands him back the coin, “references an Alāxyon (Hun) king named Mehrkurrag. However, while the reading of the second compound as *hat (kulāf)* serves your narrative, its meaning probably is colt (*kurrag*), young stallion.”

—“I was wondering, Your Majesty, the fire altar on the reverse, does that mean he is of your faith?”

—“Not necessarily. Recognizability ensures good-faith receipt of its monetary value.”

—“Ah, that clarifies that, for I once heard that he issued an edict to destroy all the priests through the five countries of India, to overthrow the law of

God, and leave nothing remaining.¹¹

—“The victor is praised only until his defeat, after which he is vilified,” *Pargast*, there is something to think about, “As to the Iron Gates, they guard a mercantile corridor in Chaginigān, between Baḫl (Bactria) and Samarkand, most recently captured by Lord Wahrām Choben, but *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens] Gordiyag had to relinquish control back to the Turk.” This Wahrām Choben, the brother of *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* Gordiyag, yeah, he was worthy of his own epic too. One day he is going to sit down and write the siblings’ tale. *Alā*, if he can convince the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* to tell it to him!

—“Thanks for clarifying that, Your Majesty.” But the *Bāmbishn* has not finished yet.

—“Most intriguing, this postulate of a singular particle, a primeval atom, from which all else stems forth.”

—“Oh, God the Dot and then a Big Bang: kaboom, ha, ha. I just made that up, Your Majesty. You should not take it serious.”

—“Perhaps not, but it is the only cosmogony explaining spherical symmetry.” What about that? He has no idea what the *Bāmbishn* means with all that, but perhaps one day, smart enough people would understand it and start preaching the doctrine of antheism, ha, ha.

¹¹Xuanzhang, 4.1.